> But it was said that they despised him in their hearts and were offended that he had returned with a foreign army. They said he had shown the English the way into their country, and that shortly they would take possession of it. They would use it as they had done all Hindustan and introduce their detested rules and laws. It was this that enraged them. They said that if the Shah had come with his own army alone, all would have been well, but their anger grew when they saw the English army was not returning to Hindustan . . . Although they were repeatedly told that the British had not come to take their country away from them, they could not forget the history of Hindustan.[61]

Before long orders had gone out that no sepoys or British troops could stray out of the camp 'unless going in a body and well armed'.[62] It was a ruling that would never be lifted for the rest of the occupation. For all their claims to be restoring peace to Afghanistan, and to be there at the invitation of the lawful sovereign of the country, the British were under no illusions as to how unpopular they were, and knew that the minute they stepped outside their heavily guarded cantonments they were likely to have their throats cut.

It was in response to this crescendo of attacks that Lord Auckland now took the fatal step of deciding to keep British troops in Afghanistan after Shah Shuja had been re-established on his throne, writing to London that 'we must for a time be prepared to support the Shah where we have placed him'.[63]

While Shah Shuja was being installed in Kandahar, Wade and Prince Timur were making rather less progress in Peshawar. Despite Wade's disbursement of over 50,000 rupees in bribes, there was no sign that the Khyber tribes were ready to let Shuja's forces through. Still less were they willing to perform any of the acts of subterfuge suggested by Wade such as seizing the fort of Ali Masjid just below the top of the pass or 'invading and taking possession of Jalalabad and destroying and plundering the property' of the Barakzais there.[64] One chief replied bluntly that now that the Shah had become the friend of the infidels, 'he would fight for the sake of his religion even if all the Barakzais were exterminated'.[65]

Like Mehrab Khan of Qalat, the Afridis and the other frontier tribes had been loyal followers of Shuja and repeatedly protected him at the lowest ebb of his fortunes; at least one – Khan Bahadur Khan of the Malikdin Khel tribe – was closely related to Shuja by marriage. But all were suspicious of his new alliance with the infidel Sikhs and British. This was something Dost Mohammad successfully played on, sending messages to each that 'if